the ambassadors of Singapore and Israel several times during my tenure, officially and unofficially. Mr Yaron Mayer became a close acquaintance.[3] This also underscored the importance of having a DA in as many countries as possible.

Cyclone Nargis, a category 3 cyclone, struck Myanmar on 2 and 3 May 2008, making landfall approximately 250 km southwest of Yangon. That a cyclone was building up in the Bay of Bengal was known to all. However, most cyclones veer off towards the North and North East, making landfall either in Bangladesh/West Bengal or on the coast of Orissa. No cyclone had actually hit Myanmar in living memory, some said as much as ninety years, so there was a sense of complacency. Most people shrugged off the warnings; there was no attempt to evacuate the population along the coastline or any advisories to stock up on essentials like water, candles, etc. Even we at the embassy were complacent. Apart from shutting down the embassy a bit earlier and asking everyone to stay home, not much more was done. There were no plans to set up any emergency control room or communications centre, which would have been the SOP in India, particularly in Orissa, where they have perfected the procedures to be followed in case of a cyclone alert. We thought we just had to sit it out for one night, like any other monsoon storm. The Myanmar Navy, which should have known better, did not even bother to move their ships out of the harbour to safer bases further South. In actuality, Cyclone Nargis affected more than fifty townships, including Yangon, the country's largest city. Strong winds and heavy rain caused the greatest damage in the Ayeyarwady Delta, where a storm surge compounded the impact of the cyclone. Nargis was the worst natural disaster in the history of Myanmar.

The cyclone hit us at Yangon in the late evening and wind speeds kept building up. We had our dinner as usual. The

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